

After your gum graft

RECOVERY GUIDE · SOFT TISSUE GRAFT

Keep this guide handy
Call our office with any questions

A small piece of tissue was placed over your gum to build thicker, healthier gum around one or more teeth. The graft needs to form its own new blood supply from the tissue underneath — this happens over the first 2 weeks. During that window, the graft is fragile, and **anything that disturbs it can cause it to fail**. Most of your recovery is about leaving it alone.

TODAY	DAYS 1–14	WEEKS 2–4	MONTHS 2–6
Rest. Ice. Cool, soft foods. Don't touch the graft.	Graft forms new blood supply. No brushing or flossing at the site (flossing: 2–3 weeks).	Tissue pinks up. Sutures dissolve by weeks 3–4. Gradually resume normal hygiene.	Full color and texture match your other gums.

Leave the graft alone

Do not pull your lip up to look at it, brush it, floss it, or touch it with your tongue. Leave the graft site alone until we give you verbal permission — this is a very delicate procedure. Checking on it is the single most common reason grafts fail. The sutures and the tissue seal are holding the graft in place while it grows new blood vessels. Even gentle pulling or lifting of the lip breaks that seal.

1 The first 24 hours

BLEEDING

Some oozing from the graft or donor site is normal for a few hours. If bleeding restarts, apply a damp gauze or tea bag with *gentle* pressure (not biting) for 30–45 minutes. Keep your head elevated.

ICE FOR SWELLING

- 20 minutes on, 20 minutes off over the outside of your cheek or lip for the first 24–48 hours
- From day 3, switch to warm moist compresses
- Swelling is usually mild and peaks at 48–72 hours
- Bruising on the face is normal and can appear days later

WHAT NOT TO DO

- ✗ Don't pull your lip or cheek to look at the site
- ✗ Don't rinse, swish, or spit for 24 hours
- ✗ Don't brush, floss, or use a water flosser near the graft
- ✗ No straws or sucking motions for 72 hours
- ✗ Don't chew on the graft side
- ✗ No smoking, vaping, or smokeless tobacco for 1 month — this is one of the top reasons grafts fail

IF TISSUE WAS TAKEN FROM THE ROOF OF YOUR MOUTH

Taking care of the palate (donor site)

Many patients find the palate actually feels more sore than the graft site itself — the tissue there is thin and we took a small piece of it. It will heal completely over 2–3 weeks.

- A small amount of bleeding from the palate is normal for the first day. Apply gentle pressure with gauze if needed.
- If you were given a **palatal stent or bandage**, wear it as directed — it protects the area while you eat.
- Avoid hot or spicy foods for 72 hours, and acidic or crunchy foods on the palate for 2 weeks.
- You may feel a raw, tender spot on the roof of your mouth — this will gradually close over.
- Don't probe the area with your tongue.

Weeks one through four

GUM GRAFT RECOVERY · CONTINUED

2 Medications, rinsing & hygiene

Most gum graft patients need pain medication for only 2–4 days. A combination of **ibuprofen + acetaminophen** is usually more than enough — see your **Medication Guide** for dosing.

CHLORHEXIDINE RINSE

Because you can't brush near the graft, a prescribed chlorhexidine rinse (Peridex, Paradex, Periogard) keeps the area clean. Start it 2 days before surgery, morning and night. After surgery, **soak gently twice a day for 2 weeks** (skip the evening of surgery — no rinsing for 24 hours): let it pool over the site, tilt your head gently, then let it fall out — **never swish forcefully**. Don't eat or drink for 30 minutes after. **After those 2 weeks, switch to a swab**: a cotton-tipped applicator (Q-tip) saturated with Peridex, wiped gently along the site as the last step of your oral hygiene at bedtime and again in the morning after eating and drinking — until we tell you to stop.

BRUSHING & FLOSSING

- Brush the rest of your teeth normally starting the day after surgery
- **Do not brush the graft or the teeth right next to it for 2 weeks**
- Do not floss near the graft for 2–3 weeks
- After 2 weeks, use a *very soft* toothbrush with light pressure — we'll guide you at your follow-up
- No water flossers, electric toothbrushes, or whitening products near the site for about a month

3 Diet

Soft, cool foods for at least the first week. Don't chew directly on the graft side for **2 weeks**.

GOOD CHOICES

- ✓ Yogurt, cottage cheese, pudding
- ✓ Smoothies (spoon, no straw)
- ✓ Mashed potatoes, oatmeal
- ✓ Scrambled eggs, soft fish
- ✓ Lukewarm soup

AVOID

- ✗ Hard, crunchy, or sharp foods
- ✗ Hot or spicy foods for 72 hours (can restart bleeding)
- ✗ Acidic foods on the palate for 2 weeks
- ✗ Seeds, nuts, popcorn, chips
- ✗ Chewing directly on the graft side
- ✗ Alcohol for at least 72 hours

4 What's normal vs. what's not

NORMAL (EXPECTED)

- ✓ The graft looking **white, gray, or pale** — this is normal for 1–2 weeks, not a sign of failure
- ✓ Mild swelling peaking at 48–72h
- ✓ Bruising on the face that can appear days later
- ✓ Raw, tender feeling on the palate
- ✓ Sutures gradually dissolving or coming loose over 3–4 weeks
- ✓ Slight shrinkage of the graft as it heals (some is expected)
- ✓ Mild soreness that steadily improves

CALL OUR OFFICE

- ✗ The graft turns **dark purple, blue, or black**
- ✗ The graft falls off or comes loose
- ✗ Heavy bleeding from the palate that won't stop after 30–45 min of gentle pressure
- ✗ Severe pain on day 3–5 that medication doesn't help at all
- ✗ Pain, swelling, or bad taste that returns after you'd started to feel better
- ✗ Fever over 101°F
- ✗ A foul smell or pus from the graft area

i About the color change. In the first 1–2 weeks, the graft almost always looks white, gray, or pale — it hasn't built its blood supply yet. This is the #1 reason patients panic and call. It does *not* mean the graft has failed. By week 3, it starts looking pink, and by a few months it will match your other gums.

💡 If a suture comes loose, don't pull on it. Leave it alone — it'll fall out on its own or we'll remove it at your follow-up.

5 Other things that may help

- **No nicotine** — smoking and vaping dramatically raise the risk of graft failure. Stay off all nicotine for at least 1 month after surgery.
- **Sleep with your head elevated** for the first 2–3 nights to reduce swelling.
- **Protein** — 80–100g daily supports tissue healing.
- **Bromelain** (500 mg, 3× daily, 5–7 days) — may reduce swelling. Skip if on blood thinners or with pineapple allergy.
- **No exercise, heavy lifting, or strenuous activity** for 5 days — elevated blood pressure can restart bleeding.

When to call us

- The graft turns dark purple, blue, or black
- The graft falls off or comes loose
- Severe pain on day 3–5 that your medication doesn't help at all
- Pain, swelling, or bad taste returning after you'd started to feel better
- Heavy bleeding from the palate that won't stop after 30–45 min of gentle pressure
- Fever over 101°F
- A foul smell or pus from the graft area

URGENT — DON'T WAIT

- Difficulty breathing or swallowing
- Rapidly spreading swelling to your neck or around your eye

Call our office right away for the on-call provider. If you truly cannot breathe or swallow, call 911.

Gum grafts are slow healers — the first 2 weeks require patience and a hands-off approach. The more you leave it alone, the better it will look in a few months.

Acknowledgment & signature

I acknowledge that I have received and understand these instructions, and all my questions have been answered. I agree to follow them and to call the office with any questions or concerns.

PATIENT SIGNATURE

DATE

PATIENT PRINTED NAME

DATE OF BIRTH

PARENT / LEGAL GUARDIAN / CAREGIVER SIGNATURE (IF SIGNING FOR THE PATIENT)

DATE

PRINTED NAME

RELATIONSHIP TO PATIENT